What's unique about the growth of Alligator Gars is their fast growth in the first years of life followed by slower growth (Figure 8.6; Figure 8.7). Juvenile Alligator Gars quickly transition to fish-eating habits (Butler et al. 2018). A fish diet means the juveniles grow at 4-5 mm per day in the first three months of life, so that by the end of the first growing season they may reach 1.5 to 2 feet in length (~40–70 cm) and 8–10 pounds in weight (Sakaris et al. 2019). Despite their fast growth, young Alligator Gars are preyed upon by many larger fish.

Figure 8.6: Growth in length of Alligator Gar in Texas. Figure 8.7: Growth in weight of Alligator Gar in Texas. Long description

Figure 8.7: Growth in weight of Alligator Gar in Texas.